

Partnering with Employers: Funding Paid Co-Worker Supports as Alternative to Traditional Job Coach Model

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Session Overview

- Background on Paid Coworker Supports in Wisconsin
- Benefits of this option
- Examples
- MCO Experience
- Outcome data illustrating cost-effectiveness

Medicaid & Paid Coworker Supports

CMS Medicaid Version 3.5 HCBS Waiver Technical Guide

- Statewide rate setting methodologies, which are further described in I-2-a of the waiver application may be used to embrace new models of support that help a person obtain and maintain integrated employment in the community. **These may include co-worker support models...**

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Wisconsin's Approved 1915c Waiver: Paid Coworker Supports

- **Individual employment support services may be provided by a co-worker or other job site personnel** provided that the services are not part of the normal duties of the co-worker, supervisor or other personnel and these individuals meet the qualifications established below for individual providers of this service. **Employers may be reimbursed for supported employment services provided by co-workers.**

Vocational Rehabilitation: Paid Coworker Supports

- VR Agency may prefer to reimburse the employer directly
- VR Agency may prefer to have the SE provider pass through payment from VR to the employer (with VR also providing an admin fee for the provider)
- If contracted SE provider is able to sub-contract, paying employer should be possible. Employer is de facto subcontractor in this situation.
- VR Agency may support a one-month bridge period where VR funding reimburses both the SE provider and employer to ensure smooth transition to paid co-worker supports

Partners with Business

Wisconsin's name for partnering with employers to increase natural supports and fund paid coworker supports

Thoughtful, intentional implementation of best practices to:

1. ensure good job matches,
2. empower employers to directly train and supervise their employees with disabilities,
3. Cultivate inclusion and natural supports,
4. Maximize independence, and
5. Pave the way to negotiate formal paid coworker supports as an ongoing option.

Determining Paid Coworker Reimbursements

- Based on individual support needs of the worker
- Collaborative assessment with the employer - gleaned through workplace & task analysis, systematic instruction & data collection, observation and discussion
- Reimbursement amount based on the support time needed and the employer's costs for coworker(s) to provide the support (wages & overhead)

Wisconsin's Experience with Paid Coworker Support

- Long standing strategy used in Dane County to increase employer capacity to provide support and decrease costs of Supported Employment services
- Some implementation in Wisconsin's Self-Directed Waiver (IRIS)
- WI DD Council mini-grants led to policy initiative (5 pilot sites)

Cost-
Effectiveness
of Paid
Coworker
Supports

Janae

Employment situation: Janae works at a local community center 4 days a week, 9:00 to 11:30. Her responsibilities include room set up, light cleaning, and assistance with senior meal programs.

Need for paid on-the-job support: After conducting an analysis of Janae's on-the-job support needs, and determining the needs that are being met naturally, it is determined that Janae needs 30 to 45 minutes of support during each 2.5 hour shift to successfully accomplish all her job responsibilities.

Traditional agency support using job coach on site

• 2.5 hrs. x 4 days x 52 weeks x \$27/hour	\$14,040/yr
• -Mileage to/from site (60 miles/week)	<u>\$ 1,404/yr</u>
Total Cost	\$15,444/yr

Support provided through the Center staff

• 45 min. x 4 days x 52 weeks x \$14.67/hour)	\$2,289/yr
• -SE agency follow-along	
• (1 to 2 hours/month at \$27/hr)	<u>\$648/yr</u>
Total Cost	\$2,937/yr

Cost-Effectiveness of Paid Coworker Supports

Travis

- Employment Situation: Travis has been hired to complete food prep tasks 3 hours a day, 5 days a week in a small diner located in his hometown which is 20 miles from the closest supported employment agency.
- Need for paid on-the-job support: Travis needs intermittent support to complete his work, including cues on how to prepare specific food items that vary depending on the day’s menu. Travis needs help setting up his food prep tasks, but once set up, he can work independently to complete the task. Total direct support over the 3 hour shift is between 45 minutes and 1 hour.

Traditional agency support requires job coach on site

• -Job coach on site (3 hrs. x 5 days x 52 wks x \$27/hr)	\$21,060
• -Round-trip mileage to worksite (200 mi./wk at .45/mi)	<u>\$4,680</u>
Total Cost	\$25,740/yr

Support provided through the Kitchen staff

• 1 hour x 5 days x 52 weeks x \$20/hour	\$5,200/yr
• -SE agency follow-along (1 to 2 hours/month at \$27/hr)	<u>648/yr</u>
Total Cost	\$5,848/yr

Cost-
Effectiveness
of Paid
Coworker
Supports

Dan

- Employment Situation: Dan works at a small metal shop that fabricates benches, bike racks, etc. Dan works 30 hours a week in the machine room, assisting with clean-up throughout the day. He also performs light cleaning tasks around the office, including the break room, reception area, windows, etc. Dan needs less than 30 minutes per day of support.
- Need for paid on-the-job support: Dan needs intermittent support with problem solving and with prioritizing tasks. Dan also needs help on occasion when he cleans in the reception area to ensure that he follows through on tasks such as wiping down the office windows. Required daily support is 30 minutes or less.
- Traditional agency support (daily spot check)

• -Job coach visits site (.5 hrs. x 5 days x 52 wks x \$27/hr)	\$3,510
• -Round-trip mileage to worksite (30 mi./wk at .45/mi)	\$ 702
• Total Cost	\$4,212/yr
- Support provided through the Metal Shop staff* \$ 0/yr
- (*When asked if they needed compensation for the 30 min.
- per day of support required, the employer declined, offering to
- provide the support at no charge.)
- -SE agency follow-along (1 to 2 hours/month at \$27/hr) \$648/yr
- **Total Cost** \$ 648/yr

Outcomes from 2017-18 Mini Grants

- Financial model developed between one service provider and MCO showed potential cost savings of about 50% per person in the pilot
- New funding structure in Dane utilizing service providers as conduits for paid coworker support
- High school demonstration showed cost savings of \$1,100 per year in paraprofessional costs for one student, the other four students transitioned to natural support
- Implementation of best practices and efficiencies with one provider resulted in moving to 100% natural supports for pilot participants

Sophie at Yahara Learning Center

Traditional Supports		Coworker Paid Supports	
Job coaching hours per week (4x1 hr. + 30 minutes for transportation per visit)	6 hours	Coworker paid supports needed per week	4 hours
Cost for job coach per hour	\$15 per hour plus benefits	Cost for employer to provide coworker supports	\$15 per hour
Total weekly costs for job support	\$ 90 per week plus benefits	Total weekly reimbursement to employer for coworker supports	\$60 per week
Total annual support costs (37 weeks of employment)	\$3,330 + benefits	Total annual support costs (37 weeks of employment)	\$2,220

Legislative Action

- Awareness of direct workforce crisis – including job coaches
- Brought data, stories and people to share experiences (including employers)
- Resulted in the Passing of Act 323 for DD Council to expand Partners with Business practices further
 - First time passage of funding bill to DD Council
 - Coaching program – training and technical assistance
 - Five pilot sites selected per year

Partners with Business in the Media

News 3 Coverage of Bill Introduction:

<https://www.channel3000.com/news/new-bills-aim-to-help-people-with-disabilities-find-jobs/675050221>

Live Stream of Press Conference:

<https://www.facebook.com/WisconsinAssemblyRepublicans/videos/1658051217594038/>

Benefits of Paid Coworker Supports

- Unobtrusive – no job coaches stick out or get in the way
- No random or new job coaches
- Educated, supportive employers and coworkers
- Truly integrated and accepting work place
- Capacity for vocational agencies to get more people into jobs

Where and When PWB Works

- At small, flexible businesses. But really any business willing to provide the support!
- With employers with low turnover rates
- Where people work in teams or side by side
- For workers with intermittent needs for support
- Areas lacking job coach capacity
- When a worker needs a consistent support person
- When employers are hesitant to involve outside job coaches (confidentiality issues, complex work tasks, small workplace, previous negative experience, etc.)
- Where reimbursed coworker time does not exceed job coaching rates (may be some exceptions).
- **Handout:** Includa's tool for service providers to identify potential situations

Inclusa Experience

- Inclusa, Inc. supports 15,000 members and is the largest Managed Care Organization (MCO) in Wisconsin, serving 52 of 72 counties.
- As a MCO, Inclusa found there to be great potential in participating and adopting the PWB best practices.
- Inclusa uses a Supported Employment Outcome Based reimbursement model, which aligns with the intended goals of the PWB practices.
- Robust staff training specific to PWB has been offered.
- A collaborative approach with providers, Interdisciplinary Teams, and Members is key from a funder's perspective.

Inclusa's Experience- Provider Partnerships

Inclusa's values provider collaboration in everything we do. As it relates to PWB, here are some ways in which we approached PWB with our network providers:

- In Person Training
- Sharing of Tools and Resources
- Creation of a new Scope of Service
- On-going collaboration with an expert Employment Team at Inclusa
- Reimbursement Support; the principles of PWB, when applied appropriately, should result in cost-effectiveness for the provider. Inclusa works closely with providers to ensure this practice is sustainable.

	Provider A	Provider B
# of Members	50	47
Total Hours Worked	1385.75	2030.45
Average Hours Worked	27.72	43.20
Payment Method	Fee For Service	Outcome Based
# Hours Job Coached	1264.50	220.75
Total Paid	\$35,760.06	\$18,855.85
Payment in alternate model	\$14,864.32 (SEOB)	\$7,174.38 (FFS)

Inclusa's Experience-Sustainability

Inclusa Experience- Member Impact

The cornerstone to our work with members is collaborative, person-centered planning. Inclusa strives to understand each member's individual's strengths and passions.

- Employment is tied to many other aspects of a person's life.
- In many cases, when an individual is employed in a job they enjoy, independence in other areas of their life increases.
- Inclusa seeks feedback from Members in a variety of forums and will continue to seek feedback specific to employment experiences.

PWB Toolkit & Resources

- Overview, FAQs, Coworker Support Plan, Agreement Template, Employer Invoice Template, Co-worker Training Slides, and more:
www.letsgettoworkwi.org/index.php/for-employers/partners-with-business-toolkit
- Inclusa's Supported Employment Scope of Service including PWB model (page 6):
www.inclusa.org/wp-content/uploads/Scope-of-Service-Supported-Employment.pdf

Thank you!

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